A SMALL RACE. A LONG LESSON.

The Tortoise & the Hare

An original PaperRun retelling of the traditional fable



At the edge of a sunlit meadow, Hare admired the spring in his legs. "I could reach the old oak before you crossed this patch of grass," he told Tortoise.

Tortoise looked along the earth trail. Bright carrots marked its edges, all the way to the far hill. "Then let us race," he said. "You have your speed. I have my next step."

Hare grinned. The morning was young, the course was ready, and both of them had somewhere to go.

Every journey begins with a first step.

01 / THE CHALLENGE

Off in a cloud of dust

Two runners. Two very different rhythms.



Hare flew down the trail in a tumble of paws and sunshine. He cleared a root, sprang over a stone, and landed so lightly that the daisies barely trembled.

Behind him, Tortoise placed one foot firmly on the earth, then another. He did not try to borrow Hare's stride. He found a rhythm that belonged to him.

At the bend of the meadow, Hare glanced back. His rival was only a small shell in the distance. "This will be easy," he thought.

A quick start is only the beginning.

02 / THE LONG STRAIGHT

One rise at a time

A little earthwork. A lot of determination.



The trail narrowed into a long, straight ridge of packed earth. Gentle ramps rose from the grass; rounded humps made a small parkour course. Carrot guards stood neatly along both sides.

Tortoise climbed the first rise. Then he crossed the flat top and carefully stepped down. The next rise looked much like the last, so he gave it the same patient attention.

Far ahead, Hare reached a shady oak. He stretched his long legs and decided that a short rest could do no harm.

Small steps carry you over large stretches.

03 / THE QUIET ADVANTAGE

While Hare was dreaming

The meadow grew quiet. The race kept moving.



Under the oak, Hare folded his paws, lowered his ears, and closed his eyes. A breeze stirred the leaves. Soon he was fast asleep, dreaming of the finish.

Tortoise came up the trail. He noticed the sleeping Hare, but he neither hurried nor stopped to boast. There was still a little hill to cross, and his next step was waiting.

Sunlight moved across the path. Carrot by carrot, shadow by shadow, Tortoise passed the oak and kept going.

Even when you rest, the clock keeps running.

04 / THE FINISH

Every step counted

A finish earned one small movement at a time.



Hare woke with a start. Beyond the meadow, Tortoise was almost at the ribbon. Hare raced after him, ears streaming, but this time the remaining distance was too short.

Tortoise took one last steady step and crossed the line. When Hare arrived, Tortoise made room beside him. "You are wonderfully fast," he said. "Today, I simply kept going."

Hare caught his breath and smiled. They walked home together, past the carrots and the oak, with a little more respect for each other's pace.

Find your rhythm. Keep going. Finish your paper.

Original retelling and AI-generated illustrations created for PaperRun with ChatGPT. Based on the traditional Aesop fable.

